

relationality
correspondence
conviviality
ancestrality
breathing
balancing
recovering complexity
dwelling in time
healing
respite
imperfection
proportionality
cosmos and microcosmos
the weave of reality
listening for alternatives
towards a beyond

The Ladder, Noise, and Knots

Thoughts for Decolonizing Technology

Ovidiu Țichindeleanu and Rolando Vázquez Melken

The Ancestral Ladder and the Tools for Conviviality

Ovidiu Țichindeleanu The ladder is about 2400 years old. It was uncovered by digging up a tunnel that led into an underground shaft of the salt mine of Băile Figa, Transylvania, which is still in exploitation today. The salt mine itself comes from a geography of salt mines in the East European region where the Carpathian Mountains are coiling. Many salt springs and mineral waters are still in use today: they are sources of preservation, used for healing and pickling, and are nuclei of cultural memory. Salt is essential to a subsistence economy, which is key to any abundance economy. Salt water wells have been at the center of the East European culture of pickling and fermentation, which made possible experiments with edibles and the preservation of foodstuffs across both the change of seasons and exchanges between different peoples.

The ladder was discovered accidentally by workers whose names I do not know. I came across it in a little exhibition in Bucharest and was struck by the ladder itself and by the world opening around it: the depth of time and all the geographical, technological, and ecological connections. — What also struck me was the size and sense of the ladder. At five meters long, and with the steps at about one meter distance from one to another, this is not a ladder made for climbing up on a platform to reach perspective, but it's a ladder made for descending into the Earth.

Rolando Vazquez Melken When we were invited to write about slow technologies, or possibly about what we might call the decolonial critique of technology, I immediately thought of the Transylvanian ladder. The image of the ladder came to me as a sign of what Ivan Illich called 'tools for conviviality.'¹ It is telling us something about the unfreedom, the earthlessness and the disorientation of today's technology. It can guide us, out of the depth of time, to see through what is normalized, to understand what is going wrong with our technological life.

¹ Illich.

Illich was speaking about how a sign from the depths of history can save us from disaster. — 'I feel almost unbearable anguish when faced by the fact that only the word recovered from history should be left to us as a power for stemming disaster.'² We can think of the salt mine ladder as such a word, as a sign that is recovered from history and that can help us understand and address the disaster of the artifice and climate collapse that is upon us. It is important here to remind ourselves of the temporality of the vortex,³ which shows us how the world as artifice is inseparable from the destruction of life, and that the artifice and climate collapse belong to the disjointed temporalities of the vortex in which the centripetal movement produces the empty now of the artifice while its centrifugal movement lays waste to life on Earth.

2 |

Ibid., 110.

3 |

Vázquez Melken (2020).

This ancient ladder, as you were saying, is not to go up, but is to go into the depths of Earth. It is a sign that challenges the orientation of modern technology. The ladder's orientation is at odds with the movement of the space race, that movement out of Earth, into abstraction; an abstraction that might be space, but might also be plastic, or the artifice in general. Instead, moving towards Earth has something to do with relating back to Earth — that, for me, is the orientation of what we can call the technologies of relationality.

Next to the orientation of technology, we can think with Illich about the problem of the loss of freedom when technologies stop being tools for our action and end up instrumentalizing our actions. He brings the example of the hammer, in a similar way as we are thinking with the ancestral ladder. 'The hammer remains an instrument of the person, not the system. In a system, the user, the manager, logically, by the logic of the system, becomes part of the system.'⁴ This quote gives us in a nutshell the core of Illich's critique of technology, namely the moment in which technology is not anymore our instrument and we end up becoming instruments for the systems that we

created. This turning of instrumentality towards unfreedom is what Illich would identify as a watershed. By becoming 'users' we are in fact being used by the system. It also points towards the expansion of the forms of exploitation and extraction of life, adding the moment of consumption to the moment of production.

4 |

Illich and Cayley, 204.

We are not anymore using tools for conviviality or for relationality to be in a world of correspondence with Earth and with others, but we subsist in and through our being instrumentalized, and thus complicit with the system. It's not as if we are just passive recipients of the system, we are being incorporated in it. We are part of its instrumentality and its disorientation. We not only become functional to it, but we begin giving body to the system. We enmesh the system. By being incorporated, it is our body that becomes the corpus of the system.

The question of aesthesis addresses how this systemic incorporation controls how we perceive and experience life. It is concerned with how technological instrumentality circulates through our bodies, through our senses and substitutes a relational aesthesis with Earth and the worlds of others. This is something that has worried me for many years, namely the loss of relational worlds of meaning and their replacement with a mediated world of instruments; where what we feel and perceive and experience as reality is actually a mediated artifice that has no more relations, that has been vacated from its relations.

Enclosures and the Aesthetics of Modernity

OT When Illich wrote his manifesto on the *Tools for Conviviality*, half a century ago, he pointed to this dangerous path along which people are being incorporated into technology. However, from this very critical point Illich also tried to articulate hope, emphasizing a different path, which does not reject technology entirely, helped by what he called conviviality and convivial tools. Illich contemplated the ways in which the tools

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are intrinsic to social relationships, and he argued that 'convivial tools are those which give each person who uses them the greatest opportunity to enrich the environment.'⁵ The pathway of modern technology that you have just described goes precisely against this type of technology—the technology that would enrich the environment. On the contrary, we are dealing with endless extraction for consumption and with the impoverishment of the environment. Illich also tried to express hope by looking beyond the Eurocentric or Western-centric world: he observed that 'two thirds of mankind' are still outside this process of incorporation, or are less caught up: this part of humanity has not crossed the 'watershed' moment. Our attempt here to think slowly, to rethink technology, to decolonize the thought of technology and our relationship to the world would also be a way to recover the conviviality of tools, and a way to recover the complexity of the world, i.e. to enrich the environment.

5 |
Illich, 34.

The more we learn about technologies such as the ancestral ladder, the more we are humbled by the complexity of the world around it. Here too, the issues of matter, scale, orientation are significant: the matter and the size of the ladder are showing signs of the work of human hands that had a very important role in the making of their world. The ladder is the sign of a body that is very involved with the world. — A body of the Earth. The ladder also points to the wide geographical area of exchanges related to salt mining and salt commerce. We do not know exactly how far it was reaching, where it led, so it opens a space that our modern minds cannot comprehend, but also an enduring time—the time passed since these exchanges, the times of the cultural uses of salt, for the preservation of foodstuffs, for commerce, healing.... This world of relationalities and use-values remains to an important extent inaccessible for the modern mind. One can only be humbled by it.

Our slow view of technology can change by learning from this complexity. One more thing about modern technology

embeddedness
p.79

and its impoverishment of conviviality and of relationality: learning one step after Illich, or going one step deeper into the Earth, I would say that modern technology has a specific way of working by producing rarefied realities.⁶ Think of the film studio preparing for the making of a historical movie, or of a movie set from which everything that does not belong to the epoch of the movie is carefully removed from the shot. This purification and rarefaction of reality creates both a focus and a blindness. It creates an artificial reality—as you said, reality under the sign of the artifice. The proliferation of rarefied realities is the site of the aesthetical re-education of the modern subject: — where we are familiarized beyond our consciousness, through our senses, through formed habits, and in the bigger picture through transgenerational structures of feeling. A life lived within the proliferation of rarefied realities is a non-relational life, a transactional and objectified life, easily commodified, prone to forgetfulness, and an easy prey to bigger powers. The wellbeing of this life is always at risk, on the brink, and has to be assisted (and upon being hurt: medicalized). It is dependent on its docile incorporation into stages, white cubes, and black boxes.

6 |
Țichindeleanu.

RVM Let us follow this issue of rarefied realities by continuing to read Illich and his observation of how, for the first time, we live in enclosed realities with nothing beyond, with no beyond. 'A frontier with no beyond is something profoundly new, something which affects all our daily dealings and makes us so different from all other persons, other cultures, worlds and languages.' Before, Illich tells us, '[I]f you spoke of a limit, a horizon, the word itself implied that you spoke of a frontier leading to a beyond.'⁷ So the idea that the frontier was a liminal space between the here and a beyond—the ancestral ladder was crossing towards that beyond—then gets transformed into an enclosure, into the enclosure of the frontier with no beyond. You can see this logic of the negation of the beyond in the epistemic and aesthetic territories of the West that deny

why we move in certain
ways and not others
p.332

the possibility of an outside of their horizon of intelligibility. That enclosure is the artifice. What is lost in this process is precisely the possibility of relationality. Illich says: 'Today we can think of a world of objects, of persons, of social constellations to which nothing corresponds.'⁸ We live more and more in worlds that are enclosures, self-referential enclosures that have no correspondence. With the loss of correspondence comes the loss of relationality and the impoverishment of our experience of the real.

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Illich, 137.

8|

Ibid.

We could think of the whole regime of modernity, of the aesthetics of modernity, as those enclosures overtermining our experience of the world. Illich warns us of the loss of proportionality, and with it the loss of a world with correspondences, a world with relations, a world that cannot think of itself as being all encompassing because it knows of the beyond on the other side of its frontiers. 'This loss of proportionality points to the historical uniqueness of modernity, to its incomparability. The poetic, performative quality of existence was erased and forgotten in field after field.'⁹ From contemplating the Middle Ages, Illich's gaze begins to see how a world that had correspondence, that had proportionality, that had relationality, begins to be eroded, forgotten, and replaced by a world with no proportionality. This is one of the most striking and defining characteristics of modernity.

9|

Ibid., 136.

Knots and the Loss of Proportionality

OT His argument becomes even stronger if we corroborate Walter Benjamin's critique of the loss of analogical thinking.¹⁰ The analogical thinking of the Baroque was still a thought of correspondences. 'This is like that.' The world of Baroque analogies and correspondences gave way to the Romantic fall into the abyss: a rush to abstraction that indeed

loses proportionality, goes immediately into the depths of the biggest anxieties, but also falls into the eternal moment of immediate pleasure. This loss of proportionality and correspondence is coterminous with the establishment of infinite accumulation and infinite growth in economy and across the epistemic field, and with the entrenchment of the imaginary of the infinite. The latter 'liberates' the phantasmagoria of the infinite rush of consumption, which is today actively destroying life on Earth. Instead of building analogies, thought and expression are often succumbing from the first step to empty hyperbolae: 'like, wow,' 'like the best.' To regain the proportion of things is therefore an urgent task that needs a different kind of methodology relating to modernity: not rejecting it wholesale, but looking at the scale of things and at relations rather than objects. How much, how big, how useful is this in relation to a social group, a city, a population, a mountain? — Rethinking in terms of scale, as opposed to infinite growth, emerges as a political and philosophical task that is still to be taken up today.

10|

Benjamin.

RVM I think what is at stake is the possibility of a meaningful and joyful life. Again thinking with Illich I would say that people feel joy to the extent that their activities are relational and thus meaningful. — 'The growth of tools beyond a certain point,' says Illich, 'increases regimentation, dependence, exploitation and impotence.'¹¹ In these, our dark times, in the face of genocide, of the proliferation of war and suffering, our generation and particularly the young generation seems to be bound between indolence and impotence. There's the idea that we cannot do anything to change things, and that our option to keep on going is the path of indifference, of indolence. I worry about the proliferation of indifference in the affluent societies.

11|

Illich, 20.

identifying stakeholders
p.423

thriving above and below
p.391

And, of course, the colonial difference has always required this indifference towards the suffering of others. It even reached its worst perversion in making consumption a form of enjoying the suffering of others. Racism has been one of the key enablers of this indolent and often perverse relation to the suffering of others. The recognition that the denizens of our consumer societies are implicated in the consumption of the life of Earth and the life of others, is also a stark observation on how disgraceful and impoverished in ethical terms is the life of the dominant sectors of society. We have become incapable of carrying the suffering of others and of becoming witnesses. When we are bound to become indifferent, we are dealing with the loss of compassion and the meaninglessness of life.

OT I would say this immediately leads us to the thought that on this path of the loss of compassion we see the most advanced technologies, such as nuclear energy, becoming, indeed, some of the biggest dangers for life on Earth. On this path we are seeing that modernity is incapable of controlling its own drives. Therefore, the loss of compassion is actually a deep loss of the world itself—what you, Rolando, have called de-worlding or worldlessness. — This is happening under our own eyes, unfolding slowly, but not so slow that we cannot perceive it. And yet perception and knowledge are not enough. This ongoing loss of control over the bad drives—the proliferation of wars, the loss of control over processes that predictably lead to irreversible climate changes—comes with the paradoxical gain of a maximalist type of use-value: the maximum utility obtained through these advanced technologies, which also creates a radical loss of potential together with the loss of compassion.

Yet even within Western modernity, one can find very different understandings of science and of what science and technology could bring to the world that would not follow the same path. For instance, for Baruch Spinoza, the idea of the essence, and of a science based on reaching the essence of things, does not lead to a science that would extract the essence and then maximize and multiply the use of the extracted essence. Once you reach the essence of something, that also means that you

loss of deep
relationships
p.403

are connected. You are with it, and the task of science is to realize whether that connection is good or bad for the life force that you are. The point is to embrace the observer effect, not to purge it. For Spinoza, the point of finding essences was not to extract them, but to reach that moment of decision that is ethical, in which science and the technological tools used for advancing science would be part of an ethical choice for the benefit of life. — This opens also a different sense of the political.

Modern technology maximizes what Karl Marx called use-value, but it does so in a specific way that Marx did not get to analyze: not only by turning it into exchange value, but by extracting use-value from other systemic utilities, in the extended or multi-sector reproduction, denying thus the expanse of relationships within other worlds. Use-value should not be mistaken with monovalent use. Artists and scientists have seen this. I'm thinking for instance of the Romanian conceptual artist Mihai Olos,¹² who returned in the 1970s to wood—coming back to the sign of the ladder—as the fundamental material of his ancestral community in Maramures, Northwest Romania. Olos brought out the knots and the binds in his conceptual work, namely the technology of the connections that have made possible the Maramures wooden house, clothes, baskets, carpets, tools—all kinds of things that have emerged out of this rural civilization. The knots have a similar form. This form has brought out a plural use-value, across domains of work and life, and with an open potential. Olos' knot cannot be reduced to a monovalent use-value. It is closer to a Spinozian essence. The knot is not abstracted and extracted in order to be purified and to be put into the service of profit, and it does not become the general equivalent of exchange: its multiple uses are unfolding into a series of plural coexisting worlds: the world of house building, the world of carpentry, of agricultural tools and economical subsistence, of artistic expressions, of philosophical reflection. All these worlds of work and life rely on the technology of the knot, on this essence, without extracting it. On the contrary, one recognizes the multiplicity of its relationships to the world and one's own connection and agency of enriching this environment. — This would be an example of a difference—a technology that

a 'Good Way'
p.419

360-degree seeing
p.312

is non-modern. Maybe we shouldn't go as far as calling it decolonial, but acknowledging the complexity of the world of its uses is part of a process of decolonizing technology.

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Mihai Olos (1940–2015) was a Romanian visual and conceptual artist who rose to prominence with local and international exhibitions in the 1970s–1980s. See Olos Estate and Galeria Plan B; Dan et al.

RVM Indeed, the knot as a tool. I would say that the knot can be read as a material manifestation of a relation. I am thinking of the knots that hold the Mayan house together, or the rhythmic repetition of knots that form the weaving of a textile. The knot allows us to relate to materiality as a field of relations instead of as a series of objects. — The knot as the expression and the holding of a relation, speaks to me of the necessity to think of the movement of enjoining instead of thinking in separation. Decolonizing technology would mean to liberate the tools of relationality. Under the technological world of modernity, there are worlds of tools of relationality that carry other forms of relation to Earth, to the territory, to the community and to memory.

The Noise of Technology and the Rhythm of Life

RVM I would like us to address the relation between technology and sound. We could say that the music instrument is a tool that brings the vibration of matter in relation to time. It enables a dwelling in time where resonance and rhythm become possible. — Here it is important to highlight with Léopold Senghor that rhythm is not multiplication. Technology works in the logic of multiplicity in space, of repetition, serialization, and recombination in space, while we would say that rhythm is in time. It is like breathing.

The instrumental world of technology and modernity is the world of noise, not the world of conversation or rhythm. It is a world of noise, of the endless noise of all those enclosures, the cacophony of those enclosures that

objects as subjects
p.110

depths and
sensuality of time
p.65

are actually extracting time. They are consuming time and in consuming the time of Earth, the ancestrality of Earth, they are also consuming the lifetime of others. The fossil fuel technologies, the mining industries are a direct example of the consumption of Earth's ancestrality in modernity's now time. The noise of the world is the sound of the consumption of time.

The extraction of ancestrality and of the time of the Earth through these methods of worldlessness and earthlessness is sustaining the artifice of modernity. That's what I was thinking when you were talking about wood and how wood can be thought of as relational, connecting multiple realities, and how the logic of extraction is more about accumulation.

OT We can also perceive visually the disappearance of sounds and the emergence of noise in the way, for instance, the technological devices made from metal are made so as to eliminate the trace of the human hand from them. This is reflected prominently in modern art. Constantin Brâncuși famously created his sculptures so that one could not see the trace of his hand on them, even if they were made from wood. Wood became a transition for the pieces made of metal, on which the trace of the hand is made even more invisible. Polishing them obsessively, with the obsession of modernization, of a modernity that eliminates the trace of the hand, until the work of art is 'finished' and can stand alone in loud silence against the observer. Wood devices such as those used for weaving looms—spindle, wheel, shuttles—are all carrying the visible trace of the hand on them while also embracing a future use of the hand. — They are carrying the trace of the rhythm of the making of that tool, which has been eliminated from industrial pieces of metal, while also opening the enduring time of human agency still to come.

The fact that in the Western world we see the emergence of rock music as an expression of rebellion speaks precisely to the protest against the world of noise, but one that is expressed with the tools of noise, trying to defeat it by going through it with a piercing scream, or else giving in by trusting one sound with the totality of the meaning of life. Either way, it is the

haptic meaning
p.400

expression of a reaction. The tools of conviviality, the tools that are recovering relationality, are reorienting the sensibility to different voices and different sounds of the world: relearning to listen to the world, to the environments of work and life, relating to the land by listening to the sound and the silence of the land, to what is beyond the silence and to the ways sounds find each other and fall together in environments. That takes time, indeed, and leads to the perception of different times, scales, and rhythms. I will not dwell on it but this is an entire field for the aesthesis of liberation—to use again the phrase introduced with Walter Mignolo—that can enrich the environment instead of extracting from it. — What you call the world of noise, the world of modern technology, sounds to me like the product of utmost reduction: the sign of the over-extraction, the hyperbolic domination of presence under the sign of 'here and always and all.' Sensing the noise does not point to an issue of degrowth or to being good citizens by asking for less, but to the problem of the impossibility of discerning any difference through the noise. Hence the need for a time of respite, listening for the keys of systemic alternatives.

RVM I think it's not just about the scale, about the 'less' like in degrowth, but about a reorientation. It's about a turning, a different orientation. I wrote a paper on decolonizing design called 'Earth Precedence and the Anthropocene',¹³ that asked this question: what would it mean to design for reception, a design for listening, for grounding, for relationality? We ask the same question when it comes to art: how can we develop art for listening, for reception, for grounding, and not for extraction or for representation? —

13 |

Vázquez Melken (2017).

When you speak of the loss of the hand, of the trace of the hands, it can be read through Illich as the manifestation of the loss of proportionality, where there are no traces anymore of our relation, only a flight into abstraction. I think of plastic as that world without the hand and without time. A world that does not breathe, that is not in relation.

learning how
to restore flow
p.130

increasing the
possibility for life
to continue
p.263

One can think of famous sculptures that look like plastic or are from plastic, on which there is no trace of the hand and there is no trace of the relation. Also in architecture: the shopping mall, the museum, the white cube, the black box, all those spaces that are characterized by the flight into abstraction.

In contrast, we can recall Japanese tea ceremonies, how the tea masters will praise those ceramics that are imperfect, their path in time, and the visible touch. In the gaze of rationality, they look imperfect, but it is in their imperfection that their life dwells, that they tell a time that is there, that is vibrating through them. — This could never be replaced by a perfectly industrialized tea cup that in its perfection erases the trace of the hand. I concur with Illich that we still can learn from those works of the past.

OR This brings me back to the ladder, because that particular ladder from the salt bog is indeed a non-symmetrical ladder that has one side much longer than the other. One can speculate about its usefulness or randomness, but one can also see that, yes, in that imperfection there is a complexity to discern that we first have to acknowledge before trying to understand it. Philosophically, I'm talking about a concrete epistemic difference and the concrete movement of thought and sensibility in relation to an undetermined but recognized totality—which is not a return to idealism, but work to be done balancing, sensibly.

RVM Let me bring a final thought around Illich's preoccupation. He says that there was a basic awareness across many cultures of the correspondence between Earth and Sky, which was destroyed by Cartesian mathematics and geometry. The loss of proportionality expressed that moment in which the poetic quality of existence was erased and forgotten, field after field. In order to explain the relation to heaven and Earth, he says, 'Heaven is mirrored by Earth. The baby I saw in a woman's arms yesterday is a cosmos, a microcosmos. When I look at this baby, I see something which appears at first sight, utterly dissymmetric from what I see when I look up at the stars, and yet they fit at every point. They are both complementary and

carrying traces
p.251

mutually constitutive. That is, the existence of one implies the other.¹⁴ We have here a very deep consciousness of our relation to the whole of reality, to the weave of reality. I think that's a consciousness that got undone by the rise of the world as artifice of modern technology.

14 |

Illich, 132.

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